

Enough pink already

If there's one subject I have a lot of arguments about – online or in person – it's gender equality. I'm a feminist, but I've been called a male basher, anti-male and some much more colourful words that can't be printed. Let me go on record to state that I'm not a feminazi-type feminist, who, sadly, get a lot more air-time than they should, and in my opinion, cause damage to the cause of gender equality. However, that's not a rabbit hole I want to fall into right now.

Instead, I'm looking to get your thoughts on the role women are (or should be) playing in technology today. Our cover story looks at the role women have played in technology thus far, the kind of challenges they face in the tech world, the things some enterprising women are doing in this sphere and of course, the way we think technology will be the ultimate gender equaliser. This column, however, is about the sacrifices that need to be made first, how you can help balance the scales and why you should.

Life in the US before 1972 was pretty good. People were doing well, almost all men worked, women too, and by and large, life was somewhat like it is in India right now. Men provided, and women supplemented income but were also tasked with looking after the kids. It was a male dominated society, especially when it came to business and sports. Thus, it was obvious to people that since more boys participated in sports and went to college, more money should be spent on education and sports for boys. Perfectly logical, yes?

No. The US Congress passed Title IX of the Education Amendments in 1972, which simply said: "No person in the United States shall, on the basis of sex, be excluded from participation in, be denied the benefits of, or be subjected to discrimination under any education program or activity receiving Federal financial assistance."

What this meant was that no school could have a school science program that was targeted at boys, or spend five times as much on a boys' basketball team as a girls'...you get the picture.

Before 1972, women were actively discouraged from taking advanced math classes, or carpentry, and weren't given the same facilities to train for sports as boys. In fact, they weren't even encouraged to participate. The lack of interest was taken as a reason to provide no facilities and discourage interest, whereas, today, we know it is the other way around.

Just consider the changes that happened in the US since then:

The number of female athletes in high school went up from around 300,000 in 1972 to 3.2 million in 2011. That's 10 times more, or a 1000+ per cent increase. And no, it wasn't just a population rise, because the figure for boys went up just 20 per cent in the same period (from 3.6 to 4.4 million).

When it comes to doctorates, in 1972 a mere 11 per cent of PhDs were awarded to women in the US. Compare that to 40 per cent as of 2011. However, the figures are still skewed within science fields, as women accounted for over 50 per cent of Life Science PhDs, but only around 20 per cent of Computer Science PhDs. You can read the full report at: <http://dgit.in/AmendmentIX>

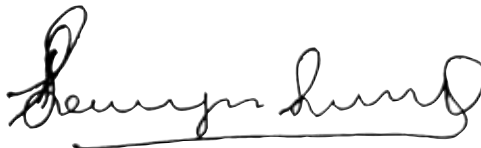
What this tells us here in India is that we certainly need to push for gender equality as the US did. That country has had the lion's share of technology innovations in the past 40 years, and something tells me this encouragement of women and breaking down of stereotypes, even forcibly when needed, actually does wonders in the long run.

Initially, I'm sure it will seem almost anti-male to a few, just as it did to the people in 1972 America (and perhaps still does to a few today as well). However, anyone who's ever pushed a stalled car knows, it takes a significantly stronger push initially to overcome inertia, and then the force applied can be gradually reduced once the car's moving.

What can YOU do? Stop stereotyping, read our cover story, don't be surprised that a woman can code, don't treat them as inferior, and actively encourage the women in your family and friends circle to try and achieve anything they want to, regardless of whether it's in a male bastion or not.

If you're a woman, encourage more women to get interested in technology in more ways than just by using it – encourage them to understand how it works. And most importantly, never use your gender as weakness or an excuse.

Personally, I think technology is missing a woman's touch. And no, I don't mean just colouring things pink. What do you think? 




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